

2012 A-Level General Paper

Paper 2 Suggested Answer Scheme

1. What does the quotation from Congreve suggest about the power of music (lines 1-2)? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
"charms to soothe the savage breast " (lines 1-2)	Music calmed/comforted [1] one when one was upset/embittered [1] Or Music "assuaged [1] emotional hurt [1]" (student's response) Or Music "placated [1] pained hearts [1]" (student's response) <u>Another possible interpretation:</u> Music has the 'ability to enrapture or pacify an uncivilised individual – a literal 'savage' – who had not encountered it before

Note: What difficulties there were with this question arose when a candidate misread "breast" as "beast" and wrote of taming wild animals.

2. In the first paragraph, what criticisms does the author make of the music he is referring to? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
...the intrusive music in cafes which overwhelms conversation; (line 3) ...the bland, repetitive background music... (line 4) ...when the music, strident or soothing... has not been selected by the listener but imposed... (lines 5-6)	He considers it to be invasive and all-pervading [1]; it makes conversation difficult [1]; the music is boring and unchanging, even jarring at times [1]; it is forced upon the listener who has no power to switch it off [1]. (Need all the points to get full marks)

Note: The careful reader of the wording of this question would have seen that it asks for the candidate to pick out criticisms the author makes of the background music he describes, and he does indeed make several after the colon following "less attractive manifestations" (the colon indicates that what will follow is supporting evidence of his view).

3. Who might dismiss the author's views as 'jaundiced' (line 8)? [1]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
Notwithstanding such complaints, which some will dismiss as jaundiced... (line 8)	Those who disagree with him. Those who write it or play it; those who use it in their stories; those who enjoy such music. (‘it’ refers to background music)

4 What **two** roles did music perform for members of the societies described in paragraph 2? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
For our earliest ancestors, their ears were a major component of their early warning system... (lines 9-10)	Music was used to alert us to dangers/threats [1];
Perhaps the earliest music was their drumming, a simple action but one inherently rhythmic, and hence it is but a short step to dance and song. (lines 11-12)	a source of entertainment [1]
For these pre-literate societies, songs encapsulated important cultural information... would be passed on to succeeding generations. (lines 13-15)	and a means of capturing essential knowledge about one's society and transmitting it to future generations[1].

5 How does the story of Orpheus in paragraph 3 demonstrate the power of his music **and** his 'human frailty' (line 24)? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
When his wife Eurydice died, Orpheus entered the underworld and played music that so enraptured the guardians of the dead that he, uniquely , was allowed to reclaim her, on the condition he did not look back until both had returned to the upper world. (lines 19-22)	A student's response: "His music was so enchanting he could obtain the exclusive privilege of bringing his wife back from the dead". [1] Or Orpheus moved even the hardest of hearts, the guardians of the dead, whom one might well assume would be implacable and unfeeling. [1] Or A student's response: "...even the protectors of the dead, who had icy hearts, were touched". [1] His "human frailty" was his impatience/inability to follow instructions. [1] (<i>'weakness' is not enough</i>)

6. Why has the author placed the sentence about perfect pitch (lines 55-57) inside brackets? [1]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
	The use of the bracket here shows that the information contained therein is additional to, not central to the main argument [1] Or It is interesting and worthy of note. [1] (some candidates called it a "fun fact")

7. Explain what the author means by calling the musical preference on social networking sites 'coded' (line 62). **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
They will readily reveal musical preferences and allegiances on social networking sites as a coded expression of their personalities and values, thereby hoping to define who they are and show how they wish to be perceived by others... (lines 61-64)	The musical preferences were symbolic/cryptic [1], oblique indicators of one's character or personality which needed interpretation. [1]

8. In paragraph 8, what contrasts does the author make between the fate of Mozart and that of some modern popular musicians? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
...Mozart was a hireling, depending on patronage , eating with the cooks and servants of his master... he endured poverty, died unregarded and was buried in an unmarked grave . (lines 74-76)	Mozart was poor and relied on support for food whereas some modern popular musicians are well paid, with some becoming very wealthy. [1]
Today, popular music provides a comfortable living for many and untold riches for some , who are feted by fans and often courted by politicians . Their deaths, particularly if premature, are occasions for mass outpourings of grief . (lines 76-78)	Mozart had no influence in society unlike some modern popular musicians who are worshipped by their followers and have great social and political influence. [1]. Mozart's death was not remembered while the death of some modern popular musicians are commemorated.[1]

Note: The question required a careful, point-by-point comparison (in terms of wealth, influence and society's response to their deaths).

9. Vocabulary

Word	1m
strident (line 5)	raucous; jarring; shrill; ear-splitting
disparate (line 25)	different; dissimilar
conducive (line 44)	encouraging; contributing to
readily (line 61)	with open arms; with no qualms or inhibitions
enigma (line 83)	puzzle; mystery

10. Using material from paragraphs 4-6 only, summarise what the author has to say about the benefits that music brings us.

Write your summary in **no more than 120 words**, not counting the opening words which are printed below. **Use your own words as far as possible.** [8]

Music is of benefit to us because...

	From the Text	Possible Paraphrase
1	...it engages and exercises so many disparate areas of the brain (lines 25-26)	it involves different parts of the brain.
2	...can bring us joy... (line 27)	It can give us happiness/offer us pleasure and
3	...or solace. (line 27)	comfort;
4	...can be profound... (line 28)	be serious and meaningful
5	...or diverting... (line 28)	or entertaining;
6	...our health improves significantly. (line 29)	and is good for one's physical well-being.
7	Socially... one's sense of community engagement and identity is enhanced (lines 31-33)	Music increases one's involvement in the community, develop one's character/heighten one's sense of self
8	Psychologically and emotionally... lifts the spirit...(line 33)	and benefits one's mental well-being/acts as a morale-booster.
9	...encourages and strengthens feelings of patriotism and belonging through national anthems... (lines 35-36))	It heightens/spurs nationalistic sentiments through national anthems and
10	...religions assign an important role to song in their liturgies. (lines 36-37)	has a significant function in religious rituals
11	...crucial to many aspects of our well-being and to our sense of ourselves. (lines 37-38)	It is also essential to our welfare and how we perceive ourselves.
12	...when allied to movement... it performs the invaluable role of distracting us from the strain of the physical endeavor and lowering our perception of its demands. (lines 39-41)	The combination of music and actions allows us to ignore pain/discomfort when we exert ourselves
13	...increases endurance. (line 41)	and helps us persevere.
14	...to achieve the right mindset, be it aggressive or reflective. (line 42)	Music allows us to adopt the appropriate attitude when required.
15	...to create an ambience conducive to spending... or to evoke reassurance and calm. (lines 44-45)	It also makes the environment comfortable/provides a source of comfort.
16	...it possesses therapeutic properties for those suffering from nervous disorders or sensory impairments... (lines 46-47)	Finally, it helps patients suffering from medical conditions
17	...can rekindle emotions and long-forgotten associations in the minds of dementia sufferers. (lines 50-51)	and has the power to revive memories for dementia patients.

Mark conversion:

1-2 = 1

3-4 = 2

5-6 = 3

7-8 = 4

9-10 = 5

11-12 = 6

13-14 = 7

≥15 = 8

11. In this article, Michael Gordon writes about some of the roles and functions music plays in modern life. To what extent do you agree or disagree with his views? Illustrate your answer by referring to the ways in which you and your society regard music. [8]

Examiners' Comments:

Music is something teenagers hold dear and have strong opinions about, and this year's passage gave plenty of scope for astute comment on some of its psychological, social and even medical benefits. Candidates did not struggle to find material in the passage with which they concurred or disagreed, but simply to offer an undeveloped list of such things, with no exploration of the topic, is a poor response.

There was almost universal agreement with the idea of music being a source of comfort and relaxation, with many candidates eloquently describing their lives as being inherently stressful and their being in need of the succor music can bring. On the other hand, the efficacy of singing the national anthem produced a wide divergence of views: many agreed that singing it together with schoolmates was an important unifying act; others felt that it was an empty ritual in which few actively participated. Either way, it would have been good to see candidates going beyond mere statement of attitude or behavior. For example, are there particular phrases in the lyrics of the anthem which successfully stir the blood? – or moments when the tune or orchestration is at its most effective? It would have made a very telling contribution to an answer to have focused on one or two such details rather than, as was often the case, making sweeping statements alone.

There was a similar divergence of views on the role of music in palliative care. Many dismissed the author's views as unscientific and certainly not to be found in Singapore, whilst others offered powerful personal testament to its effectiveness, such as the candidate who recounted how favourite music was played continually to his grandmother who was suffering from Alzheimer's and she eventually remembered her grandchildren's names. This illustrates another fruitful approach to the application question – an apt personal anecdote can add a different dimension to what can so often be an impersonal, unengaged response.

And as for music offering an attractive and potentially highly lucrative career-path, as the passage implies has been the case for a few, this view was given very short shrift, as candidates felt that parents in Singapore would certainly not see such a career as offering anything like the security of one in the traditional worlds of finance or medicine. As one candidate vividly put it, compared to a job in the financial sector 'music takes a back seat – and maybe it is even in the car boot'.

As ever, many candidates produced lively and well-structured responses, with an attention-grabbing introduction (one began "When words fail, music speaks, goes the cliché..."). Similarly, strong answers featured a variety of discourse markers to delineate and connect paragraphs, and a succinct conclusion. Weaker scripts, on the other hand, failed to include one or more of these. A

number of candidates began paragraphs thus: “In paragraph one, Gordon writes that...” to be followed by “In paragraph three, Gordon writes that...” and so on. Such a mechanistic approach does not adequately provide the coherence which is one of the four criteria used for judging success in this question.

The overall standard of candidates’ written English was as high as previous years both in terms of technical accuracy and in terms of precision and subtlety of discourse.

Naturally there are some areas in which some candidates display less command than others and the following weaknesses have been highlighted by Examiners:

- *“I agree to the author’s view that...” should be “I agree with...”*
- *it is unidiomatic to write “the author’s views are agreeable to me”*
- *the author “emphasises”, he does not “emphasise on”; he “places emphasis on” would, of course be acceptable*
- *it is much better to refer to “young people today”, not “youth today” or “youths”, as “youth” carries a pejorative weighting – if one is going to talk about “the youth of today” it is almost inevitably going to be critical of them*
- *it is unidiomatic to refer to “elderlies”; the correct usage is “the elderly”*
- *special events, such as National Day, take capital letters*
- *some candidates are prone to comma splicing, leading to over-long, rambling and disjointed sentences*

To end on a more positive note, it should be noted that the vast majority of candidates’ responses were a joy to read.